The Lantern Keeper

PREFACE

This short book was written to test how PageVoice cleans up a PDF. Every trap a real book can set is here somewhere: running heads, page numbers, notes at the foot of the page, words split at the end of a line, and more.

CHAPTER I

The Tower

The Tower Stood on a ledge of black rock, a well-known mark for every sailor on the coast, and it had stood there longer than anyone could remember.

Its keeper was a quiet man who kept a fine garden of flowers in the lee of the wall[1] and who spoke to the gulls more than to people, which suited him.

He had come to the light as a boy, and the work had become as natural to him as breathing; he could not imagine a life without the lamp.

The keeper was self-taught in most things, and he had read every book the boat had ever brought him, from sermons to an extraordinary atlas of the stars, though the extra-
ordinary volume of self-
taught seamanship had been his favourite since boyhood.



Figure 1. The lantern room at dusk.

Each night he was the only watch-man on that stretch of coast.

The keeper climbed the stair each evening with the same slow care, counting the steps under his breath as his father had done before him.

Below the tower the sea worked at the rocks without rest, and the gulls rode the wind as if it had been built for them alone.

He trimmed the wick, wiped the glass, and set the great lamp turning, so that its beam swept out across the water and back again.

On clear nights he could see the lights of the fishing boats far out, small and steady, and he liked to think that they could see his light as well.

In the morning he wrote the weather in the log: the wind, the sky, the height of the tide, and any ship that had passed in the dark.

The supply boat came once a fortnight, weather allowing, with flour and oil and

1 Sea pinks and thrift, mostly, which grow where nothing else will.

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He kept the log in a careful hand[2] and never missed a day.

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2 The log survives, though the early pages are hard to read.

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CHAPTER II

The Storm

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When the storm came at last it came from the west, as the old men had said it would.

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